✦ STEP 2

History

How Somaliland went from a British colony to joining Somalia, being bombed by its own government, breaking away, and building a democracy from scratch.

The whole story in one sentence: Somaliland was a separate colony, joined Somalia in 1960, was treated badly and then bombed, broke away in 1991, and built its own peaceful democracy while the south fell into war.

✧ Timeline

Before 1880s

Clans and herders

Somali people lived across the Horn of Africa, mostly as **herders** of camels, goats and sheep. Society was organized into **clans** (large family groups).

Most people in central and western Somaliland belong to the **Isaaq** clan. Around **Las Anod** in the east, most belong to other clans, such as the **Dhulbahante**. This explains the Las Anod dispute today.

1880s

Britain arrives

Britain made the north a **protectorate**. It held the port of **Aden** in Yemen, across the water, and needed **meat** to feed its soldiers there. **Italy** took the south, and **France** took what is now Djibouti.

June 26, 1960

Independence

British Somaliland became an independent country and was recognized by about **35 countries**.

July 1, 1960

Union with the south

Five days later, it chose to join former Italian Somaliland to form **Somalia**. The capital was **Mogadishu**, in the south, so the north quickly lost power and jobs.

Somaliland argues the **act of union was never properly ratified** by both sides.

1961

The north says no

In the vote on Somalia's new constitution, many northerners boycotted, and most northern voters **voted against it**. It passed anyway because of southern votes. Sources disagree on the exact date and numbers. VERIFY

1969

Dictatorship

General **Siad Barre** took power in a coup.

1977–78

The Ogaden War

Somalia invaded Ethiopia to take its Somali-populated region and **lost**. The government became weaker and harsher.

1981

Rebellion

Northerners formed a rebel group, the **Somali National Movement (SNM)**.

1988

The bombing of Hargeisa

Barre's government **bombed Hargeisa** and other northern cities. Much of Hargeisa was destroyed, and **tens of thousands** of Isaaq civilians were killed. Many call it the **Isaaq genocide**. Death estimates vary a lot. VERIFY

May 1991

Breaking away

Barre's government collapsed in January. In May, northern leaders met in **Burao** and declared Somaliland independent again.

1993

The Borama conference

Clan **elders** held a peace conference in **Borama** and built a government themselves, **without foreign help or money**. Parliament includes a **House of Elders** (the *Guurti*), mixing tradition with democracy.

1993 →

Meanwhile, in the south

Civil war, *Black Hawk Down* (1993), years with no real government, and later **al-Shabaab**. The U.S. didn't recognize a Somali government again until **2013**.

2003

An 80-vote election

Somaliland's first presidential election was decided by about **80 votes**. The losing side disputed the count but took it to **court**, the result stood, and there was no war. In **2010** that challenger won, and the president handed over power.

2005

The AU's own investigators

An **African Union** fact-finding mission called Somaliland's case **"historically unique and self-justified."** The AU never acted on the report. VERIFY (quoted in several articles; original report not opened)

2020

Taiwan ties

Somaliland and Taiwan opened offices in each other's capitals. China pressured Somaliland, and Somaliland refused to back down.

2023

Las Anod

Fighting broke out around **Las Anod**. Local forces pushed Somaliland's troops out. The area later formed its own government, now the **North Eastern State**, which joined **Somalia**. Somalia's president attended its leaders' inauguration in January 2026.

Jan 2024

The Ethiopia deal

Ethiopia and Somaliland signed a deal: sea access for Ethiopia, possible recognition for Somaliland. Somalia was furious. In December 2024, Ethiopia backed off (the **Ankara Declaration**).

Nov 2024

Peaceful handover

Opposition candidate **Abdirahman "Irro" Abdullahi** beat the sitting president, who stepped down peacefully.

Dec 26, 2025

Israel recognizes Somaliland

The first country to do so. The African Union, the EU, Egypt, Saudi Arabia and China condemned it.

2026

The U.S. holds its position

A State Department report to Congress reaffirmed that the U.S. considers Somaliland part of Somalia, while exploring more engagement with Somaliland. President Irro visited Washington in September and met Sen. Ted Cruz.

✧ How each side uses the history

AFF

- **Old borders, not new ones.** Somaliland was independent in 1960 and wants those same borders back. It's restoring an old country, not creating a new one.
- **It rebuilt itself.** Even after the 1988 bombings, Somaliland rebuilt and has run its own country for over 30 years.
- **The deal was broken by Somalia.** Choosing to join doesn't mean accepting being bombed by your own government.

NEG

- **It joined willingly.** Somaliland chose to join Somalia in 1960, and nobody forced it. You can't just leave because you're unhappy with how things turned out.
- **Domino effect.** If any region can leave after a bad government, lots of regions could leave.
- **Not everyone agrees.** People in Las Anod, inside Somaliland's 1960 borders, chose Somalia instead.

✧ Check yourself

✦ **Why might the people of Las Anod not want to be part of Somaliland?**

Most belong to a different clan (mainly the Dhulbahante) and feel more loyal to Somalia than to Somaliland's government, which is led mostly by the Isaaq.

✦ **Why does Somaliland say it isn't creating new borders?**

It was briefly an independent country in 1960, recognized by about 35 countries, and it only wants those same borders back.